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George Attla and Whitey.

Alice Puster



Fred Thompson

Far from Alaska's racing trails, George Attla of Huslia is shown here as he mushed to second place in the All-American Championship Sled Dog Race at Ely, Minnesota, in mid-January, 1972. Attla's time for the two 16-mile heats was 127:05.

By BELLA LEVORSEN

Editor's note: Mrs. Levorsen has recently published a book which she co-authored with George Attla. "Everything I Know About Training and Racing Sled Dogs" has 180 pages and 55 illustrations, hardcover, and is available through bookstores or from Alaska Northwest Publishing Company's book department, Box 4-EEE, Anchorage, Alaska 99509, \$7.20 postpaid.

"Attla Makes Clean Sweep." "George Cleans Up." "Attla Point Champion." These were the headlines in dog racing publications at the end of the 1972 season.

George Attla won seven of the eight races he entered in 1972, and in the eighth he placed second. This record earned him the gold medal in the International Sled Dog Racing Association's first annual point championship competition.

Success didn't come easily. George spent many hard years putting it all together.

Born in August, 1933, he grew up in the remote Indian village of Huslia, on the Koyukuk River 260 miles northwest of Fairbanks. No doubt his earliest sensations included the sound of excited dogs and the swaying of a sled, as the Attla family moved from one of their outlying trapping cabins to another and then back home again.

The villagers were a self-sufficient, practical group, and the ever-present dogs existed to haul freight and people. But races were held on weekends for amusement. George entered his first race when he was eight. It was a three-dog race that went a mile and a half.

Then trouble started. George developed tuberculosis of the right knee that put him in and out of hospitals until his mid-teens. He recovered from the disease, but his knee had to be permanently locked in order for him to walk. It was during his last two year stay in the hospital that he learned to read and write English. That was the only schooling he ever had.

In recent years George has been in and out of hospitals again. This time glaucoma is bothering his right eye. He now wears dark glasses most of the time to protect his sight.

George is not an easy person to know. When he is among strangers, he is not shy, but often seems wary, as if he is sizing you up. He will answer a direct question, but other than that he will listen rather than talk. When he gets together with his mushing buddies, however, the stream of Huslia-accented English rushes out in such a torrent that it is almost impossible for the unattuned ear to follow the conversation. In fact, he was even asked in Minnesota last winter which Indian language he was speaking!

He is avidly concerned with the welfare of his people. It is pretty well known in Alaska that no one had better try to pull a shady deal on a Huslian when George is around.

One subject he will discuss at length is the position of Huslia's people in today's world. He wants it known that the Indians can get along just as well as anybody else in the big cities. If they continue to live in Huslia, it is only because they prefer the life-style of the village.

It's natural for George to have a continuing paternal pride in Huslians, since he was their chief for several years.

George's racing career began in earnest in 1958. A complete unknown, he came out of Huslia with a borrowed team and a cast-off lead dog and shocked mushing fans by winning the World Championship Race during the Fur Rendezvous at Anchorage. He couldn't get another team together until 1962, when he again won the big race, with his famous Nellie and Tuffy in double lead.

After five lean years of borrowed dogs and races missed, a good sponsor finally backed him, in 1967. For the next two years, George sank every penny he could earn or borrow into dogs, and at last he owned his own team. His third "Rondy Race" victory was in 1968, and since then, he has always been at, or near, the top of every race he's entered.

In 1972, all the years of hard work finally jelled completely. He won his fourth World Championship Race by an amazing margin of almost eight minutes, and the Fairbanks North American by almost six minutes, another walk-away win. In truth, George cleaned up.

How did he do it? First he had to get the team. George both buys and raises dogs. When he buys, he doesn't try a dog out, he goes by the reputation of the musher who is selling. If a top musher says, "This is a good dog," then George will take his word for it. If he buys three dogs from a person and one of them turns out to be good, then he is satisfied. If all three turn out to be bummers, then he will never buy from that musher again. The mushers in Alaska know his policy and do their darnedest to offer him only good dogs. He does the same when he sells a dog. He sells only good ones to protect his reputation.

And how much do these sled dogs, with no papers and no recognition by the American Kennel Club, cost? Anywhere from \$50 for a small puppy to several thousand for a first class leader—if one is ever for sale. Two to four hundred dollars is the going price for just an average team dog.

When George raises pups he usually breeds from only a few proven dogs. Experimenting is expensive and is only done by accident.

Of course the dogs have to be housed, fed and kept healthy. Grown dogs are tethered on a five-foot length of chain and, in Huslia, usually have a small lean-to for a house. It has to be small enough for the dog's body heat to keep it warm. When covered with snow, it looks like a primeval den. Huskies can survive the Alaskan winter just curled up in a ball in the snow with their tails over their noses, but they much prefer the den.

The diet of village dogs is mainly fish, caught in the summer and dried and stored for winter use. The dogs also get any excess meat of a not-so-choice quality left over from a hunt. George's racing team is fed a balanced, commercial food all year around. As training starts, extra oil and vitamins are added to the basic diet. As the dogs work harder, the food is upgraded. The dogs are lean, like any long-distance runner, but they are well-muscled and never emaciated.

No veterinarian lives in Huslia, but George has a lot of medical know-how and equipment. When the team is within reach of professional help, however, he runs his dogs into the veterinarian's office as often as anybody else does.

What else does a championship musher need to put a 16-dog team on the race trail? Let's start with the sled. George makes his own, usually out of Huslia birch because he likes the flexibility of the wood.

Gone are the days of just wooden runners. Now they are shod with either metal or plastic. George's truck will always carry two sleds, each with a different type runner. Which one will be used depends upon the condition of the trail.

Next come lines and harnesses. George makes his own lines to exact measurements out of polyethylene rope.

The last few years his harnesses have been purchased in California.

Transportation of the dogs is a major item. They must be flown out of Huslia to Fairbanks, where they are met by the dog truck. After many years of borrowing, George now owns a truck, which he drives fast but with a sure hand. He understandably doesn't like anyone else to drive his truck when the dogs are loaded.

But before the team ever goes into Fairbanks, it has to be trained. Puppies must be broken to harness and assured that running on a team is fun. Older dogs must be conditioned for the long miles. The leaders must be taught to take the proper turns. All must learn to pass other teams smoothly and to speed up when asked. Everything is done by response to voice command only, as no lines are attached for the purpose of guiding any dog.

Dogs must be tried out in all positions of the team to see where they perform best. They must be tried out at different speeds and in different weather conditions. George takes three months in the fall to do this conditioning and training. He hopes to have it all sorted out by the time the races start in January.

Some mushers also condition themselves during this time. George doesn't do anything special along this line, because he feels that the hauling of water and feed for more than 30 dogs, driving several teams many miles every day, shoveling snow and keeping the stoves supplied with wood all adds up to sufficient exercise. One of the things he disliked most about his recent hospital stay was that he could feel himself getting soft.

Running a race is almost as complex as training procedures. First George studies all aspects of the trail—its length, curves and hills, where it is rough and where smooth, whether it is hard-packed or soft. He studies the weather and the condition of his dogs. He takes into consideration the competition and the size of the purse. He even thinks about the next race. He mixes all of these ingredients with the tricks of the trade learned the hard way and tries to come up with a winning formula.

But win or lose, George is satisfied if he can get the best possible performance out of his dogs. When he gets home from a race and puts the team out, he always takes the time to talk it over privately with each individual dog and tell each one that he did a good job.

George takes pains to nurture a bond of affection and respect between himself and each dog on his team. He feels that in the final analysis, other things being equal, success lies upon the strength of this bond. ■



Anchorage Daily Times photo by Alice Puster

George Attla, the "Huslia Hustler" and five of the 15 dogs that brought him his fourth Anchorage Fur Rendezvous World Championship Sled Dog victory in 1972 are shown in action on Fourth Avenue. Winning each of three 25-mile heats, Attla pocketed \$3,500 for his win in 315 minutes, 27 seconds.